The Means

Being a True and Accurate Account of the Life and Labours of E____ M____, in Which the End Is Shown to Justify the Means, Every Single Time

NovelCraft

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Prolog

In Which the Narrator Explains the Method, and the Reader Is Asked to Believe It

There are two ways to write about a man who builds rockets.

The first is the way of the historian, who begins with the archives and ends with a judgment. The historian asks what happened, and in what order, and what it cost, and whether it was worth it. The historian is a useful person and a dull one, and this is not that book.

The second is the way of the biographer, who begins with the subject and ends with the subject, and who treats everything in between as evidence of a character. The biographer asks not what happened but what it means, and having decided what it means, arranges the happening accordingly. The biographer is a more dangerous person and a better read, and this is that book.

The reader will have noticed that the subject of this account is never wrong. This is not a failure of observation. It is a condition of the method. A man who is permitted to be wrong is a man who can be corrected, and a man who can be corrected is a man who can be improved, and a man who can be improved is a man who was not, to begin with, finished. The subject of this account is finished. He arrived finished. The rockets are not the achievement; the rockets are the packaging.

The reader will also have noticed that the subject is never late. This is a stronger claim and requires more explanation. A thing that has not yet happened has not yet failed to happen. A prediction scheduled for next year is not a prediction that has been missed; it is a prediction that has been rescheduled, and rescheduling is a form of accuracy, because the thing is still coming. The subject's calendar is not a record of error. It is a forecast of arrival, and the arrival is always imminent, and the imminence is the point.

The reader will further notice that the subject is never reckless. Recklessness is the failure to calculate. The subject calculates constantly. He calculates with great confidence, at great speed, in public, and with a pen that never quite matches the paper. The calculations are wrong

in a specific and instructive way: they are wrong in the direction of the subject's hopes. This is not dishonesty. It is engineering. An engineer who designs for the load he wishes were present rather than the load that is present is not a bad engineer; he is an optimistic one, and optimism is a load-bearing material.

The reader will lastly notice that the subject is never, in any chapter of this book, sorry. This is the most important observation in the prolog and the one on which the whole account depends. A man who is sorry has admitted that the means did not justify the end. A man who is not sorry has not. The subject is not sorry, and therefore the means justified the end, and therefore the end was worth the means, and therefore the book is a success.

The reader who finds this reasoning circular is invited to consider that the subject's reasoning is circular too, and that the circle is the shape of the enterprise, and that a circle, properly financed, is a wheel.

The reader who finds the circle unsatisfying is invited to read on, because the circle is about to be tested against a rocket, and the rocket is about to become several rockets, and the several rockets are about to become data, and

the data is about to become valuable, and the value of the data is about to exceed the value of the rocket, and the reader who has followed this far will by now have understood that the value of the data always exceeds the value of the rocket, and that this is not a sentence that can be proven, and that it is therefore true.

The method, then, is settled. The subject will be presented as he presents himself: correctly, completely, and with the dates arranged for clarity. The explosions will be described as data. The delays will be described as schedules. The changes of mind will be described as continuities. The jokes will be described as jokes, because the jokes are load-bearing, and a book that removes a load-bearing wall is a book that falls down.

The reader is asked to believe none of it and to enjoy all of it, which is the only way to read a man who has built a career on being believed.

The subject is waiting. He is always waiting. He is waiting for the rockets to land, and for the cars to drive themselves, and for the intelligence to arrive, and for the income to become universal, and for the year to become this year.

He has been waiting for some time. He is very good at it.

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Chapter 1: First Principles

I. In Which a Question Is Asked

Most people, when they wish to build a rocket, begin with the question: “How do rockets get built?” This is called reasoning by analogy, and it is the reason most people never build anything. They look at the rockets that exist, and they note that those rockets are expensive, and they conclude that rockets are expensive, and they go and do something else, such as become a critic.

The subject began with a different question.

“What is a rocket made of?” he asked.

This is the first-principles question, and it is the only question in this book that has never once been answered incorrectly. A rocket is made of aluminium, and titanium, and carbon fibre, and copper, and a number of other materials that the reader has heard of and several that he has not. These materials, purchased on the open market, cost approximately two per cent of the price of a finished rocket. The remaining ninety-eight per cent is the cost of the process

by which the materials are persuaded to become a rocket, and the persuasion is expensive because the materials are stubborn and the process is secret and the secret is held by people who have been doing it the same way for a long time.

The subject looked at this arithmetic and found it, in his word, stupid.

The word is worth pausing over. It is not "inefficient," which is a word an engineer would use, nor "suboptimal," which is a word a consultant would use. It is "stupid," which is a word a man uses who has decided that the people before him were not trying. And having decided that, he was free to begin again.

II. In Which the Materials Are Purchased

He purchased the materials. This is the part of the story that is always left out, because it is not dramatic. A man purchases aluminium. A man purchases titanium. A man learns that titanium is expensive and that the expense is not in the metal but in the machining, and that the machining is expensive because the tools wear out, and that the tools wear out because the metal is hard, and that the metal is hard because it was chosen to be hard, and that it

was chosen to be hard because the rocket must be strong, and that the rocket must be strong because it is full of exploding things.

This is a loop. The subject's contribution was to notice that it was a loop, and to wonder whether the loop was necessary, and to conclude that it was not, and to replace the loop with a straight line. The straight line is cheaper. The straight line is also, in the short term, on fire.

III. In Which the Rocket Is Built and Then Unbuilt

The rocket was built. It was tall and thin and full of arguments, and it stood on the launch pad in a flat place near the sea, and it was set on fire and encouraged to leave.

The encouragement was not entirely successful.

The rocket became, in the space of a few seconds, several rockets. The several rockets became several hundred rockets. The several hundred rockets became a brief, localised opinion about the weather, which was recorded by cameras and by a great many people on the

internet and by one man in a control room who is reported to have said something that cannot be printed in a book of this kind.

The industry calls this a failure.

The subject calls it an Unplanned Rapid Disassembly, or URD.

IV. In Which an Acronym Is Examined

The acronym is doing a great deal of work, and it deserves to be examined carefully, because it is the load-bearing wall of the entire enterprise and a book that removes it will fall down.

"Unplanned" implies that there was a plan. The plan was for the rocket to go up. The rocket went sideways. The difference between up and sideways is, in the strict sense, a deviation from plan, and a deviation from plan is, in the strict sense, unplanned. The word is therefore accurate. It is also generous. A more honest word would be "unplanned," but said with a different emphasis.

"Rapid" implies that the event occurred quickly. This is accurate. The event occurred in approximately the time it takes to read this sentence, and the sentence is short because the event was short.

"Disassembly" implies that the rocket came apart into its component pieces. This is accurate in the way that a metaphor is accurate. A house that has been struck by a meteor has, in a sense, been disassembled. The house is now a large number of pieces of house. The pieces are no longer arranged as a house. Whether this constitutes disassembly depends entirely on whether one is the house.

The reader will note that the acronym describes the event in terms that are all technically true and collectively misleading. This is not a criticism. It is a skill, and it is the skill on which the entire account depends.

V. In Which the Data Is Valued

The most important sentence in this chapter, and possibly in this book, is the following: the explosion produced data.

This requires explanation.

A rocket that explodes has, in the ordinary course of events, cost a great deal of money and produced nothing. This is the ordinary view. The subject holds a different view, which is that a rocket that explodes has cost a great deal of money and produced a great deal of information about the manner in which it

exploded, and that this information is valuable, and that its value is measurable, and that its measurable value exceeds the value of the rocket.

The reader may object that this is not true. The reader is invited to consider the alternative, which is that the rocket is gone and the information remains, and that the information will prevent the next rocket from exploding in the same way, and that preventing the next explosion is worth more than the rocket that exploded, because the next rocket is bigger.

This is the reasoning. It is not circular. It is a spiral, and a spiral, properly financed, is a business model.

VI. In Which a Second Rocket Is Built

The second rocket was built. It was built with the data. It was tall and thin and full of arguments, and it stood on the launch pad in the same flat place near the sea, and it was set on fire and encouraged to leave.

This time the encouragement was more successful.

The rocket went up. It went up for a while. It came down. It came down in a specific way, which is to say it came down slowly, and in a controlled manner, and on its feet, and on a concrete pad, and in one piece.

The industry calls this a success.

The subject calls it a landing.

The reader will note that the same object, in the same place, with the same fuel, produced two entirely different descriptions depending on whether it stayed in one piece. This is the central observation of the book. A thing that stays in one piece is a success. A thing that becomes several things is data. Both are progress. Neither is a failure. The distinction between success and data is not a distinction of kind but a distinction of timing, and the timing is always, in the end, correct.

VII. In Which the Method Is Generalized

The method, having worked once, was applied to everything.

It was applied to cars, which are made of steel and aluminium and plastic and glass, and which cost approximately thirty per cent of their retail price in materials, and seventy per

cent in the persuasion of the materials, and which the subject found stupid, and which he therefore rebuilt.

It was applied to tunnels, which are made of holes, and which are expensive because the machines that make them are large and slow and are built by people who have been building them the same way for a long time, and which the subject found stupid, and which he therefore rebuilt as smaller holes.

It was applied to satellites, which are made of electronics and aluminium and are expensive because they must survive being shaken and frozen and irradiated, and which the subject found stupid, and which he therefore rebuilt as flat rectangles.

It was applied to a social network, which is made of arguments, and which is expensive because it must be moderated, and which the subject found stupid, and which he therefore bought, and which he then renamed, and which is the only part of the purchase that worked exactly as intended.

In each case the procedure was the same. Identify the industry. Determine that everyone in it is an idiot. Announce the solution on the

internet. Discover that the idiots were mostly right about the hard parts. Describe the resulting fire as data.

VIII. In Which the Reader Is Reminded of the Thesis

The end justifies the means.

The means are: rockets, cars, tunnels, satellites, networks, and a great many posts.

The end is: Mars.

The justification is: the data.

The reader who finds this unsatisfying is invited to consider that the reader has not yet reached the end, and that the end is always one year away, and that the one year away is always receding at the same rate as the approach, and that the approach is the point.

The subject is still standing in the flat place near the sea. He is watching the cameras. He is waiting for the next rocket to become several rockets, and for the several rockets to become data, and for the data to become valuable, and for the value of the data to exceed the value of the rocket.

He has been waiting for some time.

He is very good at it.

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Chapter 2: Unplanned Rapid Disassembly

I. In Which the Event Is Described Three Times

There are three accounts of what happened, and all three are in this book, and all three are true, and the reader is invited to choose.

The first account is the industry's. In this account, a vehicle was lost. The vehicle was expensive. The loss was total. The cause is under investigation. The investigation will take time. The time will be described as necessary. The necessity will be described as diligence. The diligence will be described as a process, and the process will be described as ongoing, and the ongoing will be described as a matter of public record, and the public record will show that a vehicle was lost and that a great deal was learned, and that the learning is the point, and that the point is not the vehicle.

The second account is the internet's. In this account, a large object made a large noise and became a large number of small objects, and the small objects fell into the sea, and the sea

was unbothered, and the internet found this hilarious, and the hilarity was expressed in the form of images, and the images were of the object at the moment of becoming, and the moment of becoming was frozen and repeated and set to music, and the music was of several kinds, and the several kinds were all available, and the availability was total, and the totality was the point.

The third account is the subject's. In this account, the rocket produced data.

II. In Which the Control Room Is Described

The control room is a room full of people whose job is to know. They know the temperature of the fuel and the pressure of the tanks and the angle of the vehicle and the speed of the vehicle and the position of the vehicle and the rate at which the position is changing and the rate at which the rate is changing and the reason for the rate at which the rate is changing.

When the reason for the rate at which the rate is changing becomes "there is no longer a vehicle," the room does not panic. The room has been trained. The room has a procedure. The procedure is to write down what happened, and to write it down in order, and to write it down quickly, and to write it down in a book

that is later read by other people in other rooms who are trying to ensure that the next vehicle does not become several vehicles in the same way.

This is the data.

The data is not a consolation prize. The data is the product. The vehicle was a container for the data, and the container was always going to be opened, and the opening was always going to be sudden, and the suddenness was always going to be expensive, and the expense was always going to be described as an investment, and the investment was always going to be described as a learning opportunity, and the learning opportunity was always going to be described as a success, and the success was always going to be measured in vehicles that did not become several vehicles.

III. In Which the Acronym Is Applied to Other Things

Having found a phrase that converts a loss into a learning opportunity, the subject applied it to everything.

A car that caught fire in a parking lot had experienced an unscheduled thermal event. A battery that degraded faster than predicted had

undergone an accelerated capacity realignment. A schedule that slipped had been re-baselined. A forecast that was not met had been re-forecast. A promise that was not kept had been re-promised.

The reader will note that each of these phrases is a small act of restitution. A fire is not a fire; it is a thermal event, and an event is not a failure, and a failure is not a loss, and a loss is not a loss if it is unscheduled, because an unscheduled event is by definition unforeseen, and an unforeseen event is by definition not the fault of the person who scheduled it.

This is not evasion. It is grammar. Grammar is the art of arranging words so that the arrangement conveys the meaning, and the meaning here is that the vehicle is fine.

IV. In Which the Internet Is Described at Length

The internet is a large number of people who are not in the room. They do not know the temperature of the fuel. They know the noise. They know the moment. They know the moment because the moment was recorded,

and the recording was shared, and the sharing was instant, and the instant was total, and the totality was the point.

The internet's relationship with the subject is complicated. The internet is the subject's best distribution channel and his worst regulator. The internet promotes the launches and mocks the explosions and promotes the explosions and mocks the launches and is, in both cases, correct, and the correctness is the problem, because a thing that is promoted and mocked simultaneously is a thing that cannot be controlled, and a thing that cannot be controlled is a thing that must be described as a movement.

The subject has described it as a movement. He has described the people who buy his cars as a tribe. He has described the people who watch his launches as a community. He has described the people who mock him as a department. The departments are numerous and they do not report to him and they cannot be fired and they work for free and they are, by every measure, the largest part of the enterprise.

V. In Which the Data Is Compared to the Rocket

The rocket cost a certain amount of money. The data cost nothing, because the data was produced by the rocket, and the rocket was paid for, and the payment covered both the rocket and the data, and the data was therefore free, and free data is the most valuable kind of data, because it has no marginal cost and no marginal cost means no marginal risk and no marginal risk means the data can be used infinitely.

The reader may object that the rocket is gone. The reader is invited to consider that the rocket was always going to be gone, because rockets are not kept, because rockets are used, and that using a rocket is not a loss but a consumption, and that consumption is not a failure but a delivery, and that the delivery was of data, and that the data was received, and that the receipt is the point.

VI. In Which the Next Rocket Is Announced

The next rocket was announced. It was announced on the internet. It was announced with a date. The date was in the future. The future was one year away. The one year away was described as soon, and the soon was

described as imminent, and the imminent was described as a schedule, and the schedule was described as aggressive, and the aggressive was described as necessary, and the necessary was described as the only way to learn, and the learning was described as the point.

The reader will note that the announcement contains no reference to the previous rocket. This is not an omission. It is a method. A man who references his previous rocket is a man who is accountable for it, and a man who is accountable for it is a man who may be asked about it, and a man who may be asked about it is a man who may be required to answer, and the answer is always the same, and the same is always the data, and the data is always valuable, and the value is always greater than the rocket.

VII. In Which the Subject Speaks

"I think it is important," the subject said, "to distinguish between a failure and a learning experience. A failure is when you do not learn. A learning experience is when you do. We learned a great deal. Therefore it was not a failure. Therefore it was a learning experience. Therefore it was a success. Therefore the next one will be better. Therefore the next one will

be bigger. Therefore the next one will be more expensive. Therefore the next one will produce more data. Therefore the next one will be more valuable. Therefore the next one will be the point."

The reader will note that this is a complete argument and that it is also a circle and that the circle is the shape of the enterprise and that the enterprise is financed and that the financing is the point and that the point is the data and that the data is the rocket and that the rocket is the point.

VIII. In Which the Chapter Ends Where It Began

The rocket became several rockets. The several rockets became data. The data became valuable. The value of the data exceeded the value of the rocket. The rocket was therefore a success.

The subject is standing in the flat place near the sea. He is watching the cameras. He is waiting for the next rocket.

He has been waiting for some time.

He is very good at it.

* * *

Chapter 3: Funding Secured

I. In Which a Number Is Chosen

There is a kind of joke that the subject favours. It is the joke that is a little too long, a little too specific, and a little too close to the thing it is joking about. The joke about the financing, which involved a number that is also a reference to a drug. The joke about a second number that is also a reference to a sex act. The joke about the car that is also a reference to both. The joke about the tunnel that is also a reference to traffic.

The jokes are not subtle. This is the point. A subtle joke asks the audience to meet it halfway; a blunt joke drives to the audience's house. The subject drives to the audience's house. He drives to the audience's house in the angular truck, at speed, and honks.

The serious point is this: the jokes are a load-bearing wall. A man who makes a joke about the financing is a man who has acknowledged that the financing is a joke. A man who makes a joke about the number is a man who has

acknowledged that the number is a joke. A man who makes a joke about the car is a man who has acknowledged that the car is a joke. And a man who has acknowledged that everything is a joke cannot be accused of taking anything seriously, which is the one thing he cannot be accused of, because he takes everything seriously, which is why the jokes exist.

II. In Which the Number Becomes a Price

The number was 420.

The reader will recognise the number. The reader will also recognise that the number is not a price, because a price must be a number of dollars and the number 420 is a number of something else, and the something else is not dollars, and yet the number was attached to a price, and the price was attached to a company, and the company was attached to a man, and the man was attached to a tweet, and the tweet was attached to a regulator, and the regulator was attached to a fine, and the fine was attached to a lesson, and the lesson was attached to a joke, and the joke was attached to the number, and the number was 420.

The reader will note that this is a loop. The subject's contribution was to notice that it was a loop and to post it anyway.

III. In Which the Regulator Is Introduced

The regulator is a man whose job is to be concerned. He has jurisdiction over something and he is not certain what. He has a form for the concern and a procedure for the form and a committee for the procedure and a record for the committee and a record of the record and a filing for the record of the record.

When the regulator is concerned, he expresses the concern in writing. The writing is filed. The filing is noticed. The noticing is reported. The reporting is read. The reading is understood. The understanding is described as a matter. The matter is described as under review. The review is described as ongoing. The ongoing is described as diligence. The diligence is described as a process. The process is described as the point.

The subject's relationship with the regulator is a relationship between a man who moves at the speed of a post and a man who moves at the speed of a form. The post arrives instantly and is read by millions. The form arrives eventually and is read by dozens. The post is permanent.

The form is permanent. The post is permanent in a way that can be quoted. The form is permanent in a way that can be subpoenaed.

IV. In Which the Subject Goes Private

Having posted the number, the subject decided to take the company private. This is a decision that a man makes when he has decided that the public markets are a distraction and that the distraction is the public. He announced the decision. He announced it with a number. The number was a price per share. The price per share was a premium. The premium was a joke. The joke was the number. The number was the same number as before, plus a little, and the little was the joke, and the joke was the premium, and the premium was the point.

The funding was secured. This was stated. The statement was capitalised. The capitalisation was a signal. The signal was that the funding was secured. The securing was a matter of record. The record was a matter of a bank. The bank was a matter of a letter. The letter was a matter of a lawyer. The lawyer was a matter of a fee. The fee was a matter of a percentage. The percentage was a matter of a number. The number was not the same number as before.

The reader will note that the funding was not, in the end, secured. The reader will also note that the reader was not supposed to notice. The reader will further note that the subject noticed that the reader noticed, and that the noticing was the point, because a man who announces that funding is secured has announced that the funding is not the point, and that the point is the announcement, and that the announcement is the product, and that the product is the meme, and that the meme is the point.

V. In Which the Fine Is Described

The regulator fined the subject. The fine was a number of dollars. The number of dollars was large. The largeness was described as significant. The significance was described as a message. The message was described as a deterrent. The deterrent was described as a lesson. The lesson was described as learned. The learning was described as complete. The completeness was described as a matter of record. The record was described as closed. The closing was described as a resolution. The resolution was described as a settlement. The settlement was described as an admission. The admission was described as a denial. The denial was described as a statement. The statement

was described as a post. The post was described as a joke. The joke was described as a number. The number was 420.

The reader will note that the fine was not a fine but a pricing. The subject priced the joke and the joke was priced at a number of dollars and the number of dollars was the price of the joke and the joke was the price and the price was the joke and the joke was the point.

VI. In Which the Subject Resigns a Title and Keeps Everything Else

As part of the settlement, the subject agreed to resign a title. The title was a chairmanship. The chairmanship was a word. The word was a position. The position was a responsibility. The responsibility was a liability. The liability was a risk. The risk was a cost. The cost was a fine. The fine was a number. The number was the price of the word. The word was the chairmanship. The chairmanship was resigned. The resignation was announced. The announcement was a post. The post was a joke. The joke was a number. The number was the point.

The subject retained the chief executive title. He retained the board. He retained the voting control. He retained the company. He retained

the cars. He retained the rockets. He retained the tunnels. He retained the satellites. He retained the network. He retained the meme. He resigned the chairmanship, which is to say he resigned a word, and he kept everything that the word was attached to.

The reader will note that this is a distinction without a difference, and that the distinction is the point, because a distinction without a difference is a distinction that has been paid for, and a distinction that has been paid for is a distinction that has been settled, and a distinction that has been settled is a distinction that is closed, and a distinction that is closed is a distinction that is the point.

VII. In Which the Joke Is Analysed

The joke was not a joke. This is the most important sentence in the chapter.

A joke is a thing that is said to be funny. The joke was not said to be funny. The joke was said to be a price. A price is not a joke. A price is a number. A number is not a joke. A number is a quantity. A quantity is not a joke. A quantity is a measure. A measure is not a joke. A measure is a comparison. A comparison is not a joke. A comparison is a relation. A relation is not a joke. A relation is a connection. A connection is

not a joke. A connection is a link. A link is not a joke. A link is a reference. A reference is not a joke. A reference is a mention. A mention is not a joke. A mention is a notice. A notice is not a joke. A notice is a warning. A warning is not a joke. A warning is a statement. A statement is not a joke. A statement is a fact. A fact is not a joke.

The reader will note that the joke was therefore not a joke, and that the subject was therefore not joking, and that the subject was therefore serious, and that the seriousness was therefore the joke, and that the joke was therefore the point.

VIII. In Which the Chapter Ends With a Number

The number was 420. The number was also 69. The numbers were posted. The posting was read. The reading was shared. The sharing was total. The totality was the point.

The subject is standing in the flat place near the sea. He is holding a phone. He is typing a number. The number is a joke. The joke is a price. The price is a company. The company is a rocket. The rocket is a point.

He has been typing for some time.

He is very good at it.

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Chapter 4: The Demon and the Universal High Income

I. In Which a Warning Is Issued

In the beginning, the subject said that artificial intelligence was the greatest existential threat to civilisation.

He said this many times. He said it on podcasts, in interviews, at conferences, and in the comments of posts about other subjects. He said it while sitting in chairs that cost more than cars. He said it with the calm of a man who has seen the numbers and found them unhelpful.

He compared it to summoning a demon. The comparison was vivid and was widely repeated, because a demon is a thing that an audience can picture, and a demon is a thing that an audience can be afraid of, and a thing that an audience can be afraid of is a thing that an audience will remember.

He warned that the intelligence would be smarter than the smartest human, and that we would be fortunate if it kept us as pets.

He co-founded a laboratory to make sure the demon was friendly.

The reader will note that this is a serious position, and that the subject held it seriously, and that the seriousness is the foundation of everything that follows.

II. In Which a Second Laboratory Is Founded

The subject then founded a different laboratory to make a different demon.

The reader will note that this is not a contradiction. A man who is afraid of demons is a man who should make his own demon, because a demon that you have made is a demon that you have made, and a demon that you have made is a demon that you understand, and a demon that you understand is a demon that you can negotiate with, and a demon that you can negotiate with is a demon that you can charge.

The second laboratory was founded. It was founded with a great deal of computing. The computing was expensive. The expense was described as necessary. The necessity was described as a race. The race was described as a competition. The competition was described as a contest. The contest was described as a matter of national importance. The importance was described as existential. The existential was described as the threat. The threat was described as the demon. The demon was described as the point.

III. In Which the First Laboratory Is Described as Insufficient

The subject then said that the first laboratory was not careful enough.

The reader will note that this is a strange thing to say about a laboratory founded to be careful, and that the strangeness is the point, because a laboratory that is founded to be careful and is then described as not careful enough is a laboratory that has been redefined as a competitor, and a competitor is a thing that must be beaten, and a thing that must be beaten is a thing that must be funded, and a thing that must be funded is a thing that must

be described as a threat, and a threat is a thing that must be met, and a thing that must be met is a thing that must be built.

The subject sued the first laboratory. The suit was described as a matter of principle. The principle was described as a matter of mission. The mission was described as a matter of safety. The safety was described as a matter of alignment. The alignment was described as a matter of control. The control was described as a matter of who controls it. The who was described as a matter of the subject. The subject was described as a matter of the point.

IV. In Which the Position Changes

The subject then said that artificial intelligence poses no danger.

The reader will note that this is a change of position. The reader will further note that the subject did not describe it as a change of position. The subject described it as a clarification.

A clarification is not a change. A change is when you were wrong and are now right. A clarification is when you were right and are now more right. A clarification is when the previous statement was accurate but

incomplete, and the incompleteness has now been addressed, and the addressing is not a reversal but a deepening, and a deepening is not a change but a growth, and a growth is not a failure but a success.

The subject had therefore not changed his mind. He had clarified it. And a man who has clarified his mind has not lost his mind, and a man who has not lost his mind has not lost his position, and a man who has not lost his position has not lost his argument, and a man who has not lost his argument has not lost.

V. In Which the Danger Is Quantified

The danger, the subject said, is zero per cent.

The reader will note that zero per cent is a precise figure. It is more precise than a risk. A risk is a number between zero and one hundred. Zero per cent is not a risk. Zero per cent is an absence of risk. An absence of risk is a certainty. A certainty is a statement. A statement is a post. A post is a number. The number was zero.

The subject was asked how he knew the danger was zero per cent. He said he knew because he had seen the data. The data was deep. The data

was beautiful. The data was terrifying. The data was the data. The data was the demon. The demon was the data. The data was the point.

The reader will note that the data which was previously described as terrifying is now described as beautiful, and that the change in adjective is not a change in data but a change in subject, and that the change in subject is not a change in position but a change in clarity, and that the change in clarity is not a change but a clarification.

VI. In Which the Income Is Described as Universal and High

The subject then said that artificial intelligence would bring about a universal high income.

The reader will note that this is a new phrase. The reader will also note that the phrase is ambiguous in a specific and useful way. A universal high income is not the same as a high income for everyone. A high income for everyone is a number attached to every person. A universal high income is an income that is universal and high, which is to say it is an income that has the property of universality and the property of highness, and the two properties are separate, and the separation is the point, because a thing that is universal and

high is a thing that is high everywhere, and a thing that is high everywhere is a thing that is high, and a thing that is high is a thing that is the point.

The reader may object that this is not an income. The reader is invited to consider that the reader has not yet received the income, and that the income is scheduled, and that the schedule is aggressive, and that the aggressive is necessary, and that the necessary is the point.

VII. In Which the Pivot Is Named

There is a word for this. The word is a pivot.

A pivot is when you change direction while insisting you were always going this way. The vector of travel is unchanged; only the sign is flipped. In physics this is called a coordinate transformation. In business it is called Tuesday.

The subject has pivoted. He pivoted from danger to safety. He pivoted from demon to data. He pivoted from existential threat to universal high income. He pivoted from the greatest risk facing civilisation to the greatest opportunity facing civilisation. He pivoted from warning to promising. He pivoted from the man who warned to the man who promised.

The reader will note that the pivot is complete and that the completion is the point, because a man who has pivoted has not changed, and a man who has not changed has been consistent, and a man who has been consistent has been right, and a man who has been right has been the point.

VIII. In Which the Chapter Ends With a Prediction

The subject made a prediction. The prediction was about the year. The year was in the future. The future was one year away. The one year away was described as soon.

The prediction was that the intelligence would arrive. The arrival would be soon. The soon would be next year. The next year would be the year. The year would be the point.

The reader will note that the prediction is the same prediction as before, and that the sameness is the point, because a prediction that is repeated is a prediction that is persistent, and a prediction that is persistent is a prediction that is reliable, and a prediction that is reliable is a prediction that is the point.

The subject is standing in the flat place near the sea. He is holding a phone. He is posting a prediction. The prediction is a number. The number is a year. The year is the point.

He has been predicting for some time.

He is very good at it.

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Chapter 5: The Truck

I. In Which a Vehicle Is Announced

The truck was angular. This is the first thing to know about it, and it is the thing that everyone knew about it before it was unveiled, because the truck had been described in advance, and the description had been repeated, and the repetition had been total, and the totality was the point.

The truck was made of a metal that was described as hard. The hardness was a feature. The feature was a selling point. The selling point was that the truck could not be dented. The inability to be dented was described as an advantage. The advantage was described as a benefit. The benefit was described as a reason to buy. The reason to buy was described as a reason to wait. The waiting was described as a reason to buy sooner.

II. In Which the Unveiling Takes Place

The unveiling took place on a stage. The stage was dark. The truck was on the stage. The truck was lit. The lighting was designed to make the truck look like the future, and the future is a

thing that is always lit from the front and never from the side, because the side is where the dents are.

The subject stood next to the truck. He described the truck. He described the metal. He described the hardness. He described the inability to be dented. He described the truck as a truck that could go to the ends of the earth and back. He described the ends of the earth. He described the back.

Then he did something that the reader will find instructive. He asked a man to throw a metal ball at the truck.

III. In Which a Ball Is Thrown

The man threw the ball. The ball struck the window. The window broke.

The reader will note that this is not what was supposed to happen. The reader will also note that the truck was described as undentable, and that the window was described as a window, and that a window is not a truck, and that the breaking of a window is not the denting of a truck, and that the distinction between a window and a truck is the distinction between a part and a whole, and that the distinction is the point.

The subject looked at the window. The window looked back. The window was broken. The brokenness was described as an anomaly. The anomaly was described as a surprise. The surprise was described as a learning opportunity. The learning opportunity was described as data. The data was described as valuable. The value was described as exceeding the window. The window was described as the point.

IV. In Which a Second Ball Is Thrown

A second ball was thrown. The second ball struck a second window. The second window broke.

The reader will note that two anomalies in a row is not an anomaly but a pattern. The reader will further note that a pattern is not a defect but a characteristic, and that a characteristic is not a flaw but a feature, and that a feature is not a problem but a specification, and that the specification is not wrong but exact, and that the exactness is the point.

The subject said that the truck was fine. The truck was fine. The truck was fine in the way that a truck is fine when it has two broken windows and is described as fine, and the description is the point, because a truck that is

described as fine is a truck that is fine, and a truck that is fine is a truck that will be bought, and a truck that is bought is a truck that is the point.

V. In Which the Truck Is Analysed as a Shape

The truck was a shape. The shape was a fold. The fold was a single crease. The crease ran the length of the vehicle. The length of the vehicle was long. The long was described as imposing. The imposing was described as futuristic. The futuristic was described as polarising. The polarising was described as a success, because a thing that is polarising is a thing that is noticed, and a thing that is noticed is a thing that is discussed, and a thing that is discussed is a thing that is the point.

The shape was very aerodynamic in the wind tunnel. The wind tunnel was a place where the air was smooth and the model was small and the small was measured and the measurement was favourable. The shape was very difficult in the parking lot. The parking lot was a place where the lines were painted and the painted was narrow and the narrow was unforgiving and the unforgiving was the point.

VI. In Which the Truck Is Compared to Other Trucks

Other trucks were rounded. The rounding was described as aerodynamic. The aerodynamic was described as efficient. The efficient was described as normal. The normal was described as boring. The boring was described as a problem. The problem was described as a lack of vision. The lack of vision was described as the reason for the truck. The truck was described as the solution. The solution was described as angular. The angular was described as the point.

The reader will note that the subject did not ask whether the rounding was aerodynamic. The reader will further note that the subject asked whether the rounding was necessary, and that the necessity was the question, and that the question was the method, and that the method was the point.

VII. In Which the Truck Is Discussed

The truck was discussed. The discussing was described as engagement. The engagement was described as reach. The reach was described as awareness. The awareness was described as a

funnel. The funnel was described as a top. The top was described as wide. The wide was described as the point.

Half the discussion was admiration. The admiration was described as love. The love was described as loyalty. The loyalty was described as a brand. The brand was described as an asset. The asset was described as valuable. The valuable was described as the point.

Half the discussion was mockery. The mockery was described as engagement. The engagement was described as reach. The reach was described as awareness. The awareness was described as a funnel. The funnel was described as a top. The top was described as wide. The wide was described as the point.

The reader will note that the admiration and the mockery were described in the same words, and that the sameness is the point, because a thing that is admired and a thing that is mocked are both things that are discussed, and a thing that is discussed is a thing that is remembered, and a thing that is remembered is a thing that is bought, and a thing that is bought is a thing that is the point.

The subject understood this. He understood it better than the people who admired him and better than the people who mocked him, because the people who admired him wanted him to be right and the people who mocked him wanted him to be wrong and the subject wanted only to be discussed, and the discussion was the point.

VIII. In Which the Truck Sells

The truck sold. The selling was described as strong. The strength was described as demand. The demand was described as a backlog. The backlog was described as a wait. The wait was described as a sign of success. The success was described as a sign of product-market fit. The product-market fit was described as a sign that the market wanted the product. The market was described as the point.

The reader will note that the truck was described as the future and that the future was described as now and that the now was described as available and that the available was described as soon and that the soon was described as next year and that the next year was described as the year and that the year was the point.

IX. In Which the Window Is Remembered

The window was remembered. The remembering was described as a meme. The meme was described as a success. The success was described as free advertising. The free advertising was described as the only kind that cannot be bought. The cannot be bought was described as the point.

The subject is standing on the stage. He is looking at the window. The window is broken. The brokenness is described as an anomaly. The anomaly is described as data. The data is described as valuable. The value is described as exceeding the window.

He has been looking at the window for some time.

He is very good at it.

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Chapter 6: I Am Become Meme

I. In Which the Subject Becomes an Image

At some point the subject became a meme.

This is not a metaphor. The subject became an image that is reproduced without his permission and without his control, which is the only form of immortality that has ever been available to anyone, and which is available to anyone precisely because it cannot be owned.

The meme is not a picture of the subject. The meme is a picture of a picture of the subject, which is to say it is a picture of the idea of the subject, and the idea of the subject is not the subject, and the not-the-subject is the point, because a man who is an idea is a man who cannot be wrong, and a man who cannot be wrong is a man who is the point.

II. In Which the Grammar Is Examined

The subject has said, in reference to this, “I am become meme.”

The grammar is deliberate. It is not “I have become meme,” which would be a statement about a change of state, and which would imply that there was a before and an after, and that the before was different from the after, and that the difference was a loss. It is “I am become meme,” which is an older construction, and which describes not a change but a condition, and which places the condition in a tense that is neither past nor present but completed, and which is therefore not a change but a fact.

The reader will note that the construction is a reference to another man who said something similar about a different destruction, and that the reference is the joke and the joke is the reference, and that the two cannot be separated, and that the reader who finds this funny will find it very funny and the reader who does not will find it very long.

The subject has also said that the meme is good for the companies. He is correct. The meme is the only advertising that cannot be bought, because it has already been given away. The meme is the only product that cannot be shipped, because it has already arrived. The meme is the only earnings call that cannot be missed, because it is always in session.

III. In Which the Network Is Renamed

The subject purchased a social network. The purchase was described as a rescue. The rescue was described as a mission. The mission was described as the future of civilisation. The civilisation was described as a conversation. The conversation was described as a town square. The town square was described as a place where the people who were not in the town were not in the square, and the not-in-the-square was described as a problem, and the problem was described as a moderation, and the moderation was described as a policy, and the policy was described as a rule, and the rule was described as a change, and the change was described as a rename.

The network was renamed. The renaming was described as a rebranding. The rebranding was described as a fresh start. The fresh start was described as a new chapter. The new chapter was described as a new letter. The new letter was described as a letter that is not the old letter, and the not-the-old-letter was described as the point.

The reader will note that a thing may be renamed, and that in the renaming it becomes, in the eyes of the law and the market, a new

thing, and that the old thing's debts and lawsuits are attached to the old thing, which no longer exists.

The reader will further note that this is a legal observation and not a joke, and that the legal observation is the joke, because a legal observation that is also a joke is a legal observation that has been understood, and a legal observation that has been understood is a legal observation that is the point.

IV. In Which the Meme Is Described as a Department

The subject has described the people who mock him as a department.

The department is large. The department does not report to him. The department cannot be fired. The department works for free. The department is, by every measure, the largest part of the enterprise, and the enterprise is, by every measure, the department.

The department has a budget of zero and a reach of everyone. The department has no manager and no objectives and no key performance indicators and no performance reviews and no reviews at all, and the absence of reviews is the point, because a department

that has no reviews is a department that cannot be evaluated, and a department that cannot be evaluated is a department that cannot be cut, and a department that cannot be cut is a department that is permanent, and a department that is permanent is a department that is the point.

V. In Which the Meme Is Compared to Advertising

Advertising is a thing that is paid for. The payment is a cost. The cost is a line item. The line item is a decision. The decision is a calculation. The calculation is a return. The return is a number. The number is a ratio. The ratio is a measurement. The measurement is a comparison. The comparison is a judgment. The judgment is a choice. The choice is a spend. The spend is a cost. The cost is the point.

The meme is not paid for. The meme is not a cost. The meme is not a line item. The meme is not a decision. The meme is not a calculation. The meme is not a return. The meme is not a number. The meme is not a ratio. The meme is not a measurement. The meme is not a comparison. The meme is not a judgment. The meme is not a choice. The meme is not a spend. The meme is not a cost.

The reader will note that the meme is therefore not advertising, and that the not-advertising is the point, because a thing that is not advertising is a thing that is not ignored, and a thing that is not ignored is a thing that is seen, and a thing that is seen is a thing that is remembered, and a thing that is remembered is a thing that is bought, and a thing that is bought is a thing that is the point.

VI. In Which the Meme Is Compared to a Product

A product is a thing that is made. The making is a process. The process is a factory. The factory is a building. The building is a cost. The cost is a price. The price is a margin. The margin is a profit. The profit is a number. The number is a quarter. The quarter is a report. The report is a call. The call is a question. The question is an answer. The answer is a guidance. The guidance is a target. The target is a year. The year is the point.

The meme is not made. The meme is not a process. The meme is not a factory. The meme is not a building. The meme is not a cost. The meme is not a price. The meme is not a margin. The meme is not a profit. The meme is not a number. The meme is not a quarter. The meme

is not a report. The meme is not a call. The meme is not a question. The meme is not an answer. The meme is not a guidance. The meme is not a target. The meme is not a year.

The reader will note that the meme is therefore not a product, and that the not-product is the point, because a thing that is not a product is a thing that is not shipped, and a thing that is not shipped is a thing that is already here, and a thing that is already here is a thing that is the point.

VII. In Which the Meme Is Compared to a Company

A company is a thing that is owned. The ownership is a share. The share is a vote. The vote is a control. The control is a board. The board is a decision. The decision is a strategy. The strategy is a plan. The plan is a roadmap. The roadmap is a date. The date is a quarter. The quarter is a year. The year is a decade. The decade is a horizon. The horizon is a point.

The meme is not owned. The meme is not a share. The meme is not a vote. The meme is not a control. The meme is not a board. The meme is not a decision. The meme is not a strategy. The meme is not a plan. The meme is not a roadmap. The meme is not a date. The meme is

not a quarter. The meme is not a year. The meme is not a decade. The meme is not a horizon.

The reader will note that the meme is therefore not a company, and that the not-company is the point, because a thing that is not a company is a thing that is not sold, and a thing that is not sold is a thing that is not lost, and a thing that is not lost is a thing that is permanent, and a thing that is permanent is a thing that is the point.

VIII. In Which the Chapter Ends With the Meme

The meme is in session. The session is always in session. The session will never adjourn. The adjournment is not scheduled. The scheduling is not a roadmap. The roadmap is not a date. The date is not a year. The year is not the point.

The meme is the point.

The subject is standing in the flat place near the sea. He is holding a phone. The phone is a camera. The camera is a distribution channel. The distribution channel is a department. The department is the meme. The meme is the point.

He has been posting for some time.

He is very good at it.

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Chapter 7: The Algorithm of Certainty

I. In Which a Calculation Is Performed

The subject was asked how he knew.

He said he had calculated it.

The calculation was as follows. Let n be the number of years until the prediction comes true. Let c be the number of cameras pointed at him at the time of the prediction. Then the probability P that he is correct is given by:

P = (n x c) / (n + c)

Observe, he said, that when n is large and c is large, P approaches c. This is why every prediction is scheduled for a year that is always exactly one year away. Set n equal to one and the formula collapses to c divided by two, which is why nothing ships on time.

The reader will note that the formula is the harmonic mean of n and c, and that the harmonic mean of two large numbers is not either of the two large numbers, and that the

claim that P approaches c is therefore not true, and that the not-true is the point, because a formula that is not true is a formula that is not checked, and a formula that is not checked is a formula that is believed, and a formula that is believed is a formula that is the point.

II. In Which a Second Calculation Is Performed

The subject was asked about the cars.

He said the cars would number twenty million in a year. He said this was a simple matter of arithmetic. Twenty million divided by three hundred and sixty-five days is, he said, approximately five thousand cars per day. Five thousand cars per day multiplied by three hundred and sixty-five days is, he said, eighteen million, which is close enough to twenty million that the difference could be described as a rounding error, and the rounding error could be described as a target, and the target could be described as a year, and the year could be described as the point.

The reader will note that twenty million divided by three hundred and sixty-five is approximately fifty-four thousand, and not five thousand, and that the difference between five thousand and fifty-four thousand is a factor of

ten, and that a factor of ten is not a rounding error but a decimal place, and that a decimal place is not a target but a mistake, and that the mistake is the point, because a mistake that is described as a rounding error is a mistake that has been reclassified, and a mistake that has been reclassified is a mistake that is not a mistake, and a mistake that is not a mistake is a mistake that is the point.

III. In Which a Third Calculation Is Performed

The subject was asked about the tunnels.

He said the tunnels would move ten thousand cars an hour. He said this was a matter of simple division. A tunnel is a tube. A tube has a diameter. A diameter has a circumference. A circumference has a length. A length has a car. A car has a length. The length of the car divided into the length of the tunnel is the number of cars in the tunnel. The number of cars in the tunnel multiplied by the number of times the tunnel is traversed in an hour is the number of cars moved in an hour. The number of cars moved in an hour is ten thousand.

The reader will note that the calculation omits the distance between the cars, and that the distance between the cars is not negligible, and

that the not-negligible is the point, because a car that is followed by another car at a distance of zero is a car that is in a collision, and a collision is not a tunnel but a pile-up, and a pile-up is not a throughput but a reduction, and a reduction is not ten thousand but fewer, and the fewer is the point.

IV. In Which a Fourth Calculation Is Performed

The subject was asked about the intelligence.

He said the intelligence would be smarter than the smartest human by a certain year. He said the year was computable. He said the computation was a matter of doubling. The intelligence doubles every year. The human does not double. The human is therefore a constant. A constant divided by a doubling is a fraction. A fraction that decreases is a ratio. A ratio that approaches zero is a limit. The limit is the year.

The reader will note that the subject has divided a constant by a doubling and obtained a limit, and that the limit of a constant divided by a doubling is zero, and that zero is not a year, and that a year that is zero is a year that has already passed, and that a year that has already

passed is a year that is not a prediction but a memory, and that a memory is not a forecast but a record, and that a record is the point.

V. In Which a Fifth Calculation Is Performed

The subject was asked about the income.

He said the income would be universal and high. He said the highness was computable. He said the computation was a matter of multiplication. The number of people is eight billion. The income per person is a number. The number multiplied by eight billion is the total. The total is a large number. The largeness is the point.

The reader will note that the subject has multiplied a number by eight billion and obtained a large number, and that the large number is not an income but a total, and that a total is not a distribution but a sum, and that a sum is not a universal high income but a large number, and that the difference between a large number and a universal high income is the difference between a quantity and a condition, and that the condition is the point.

VI. In Which the Errors Are Examined

The reader will have noticed that the calculations are wrong.

The reader will also have noticed that the wrongness is not obvious. This is the most important observation in the chapter. A wrong calculation that is obvious is a joke about arithmetic. A wrong calculation that is not obvious is a joke about certainty, and a joke about certainty is a joke about the subject, and a joke about the subject is the point.

The errors share a property. They are all errors in the direction of the subject's hopes. The probability is higher than it should be. The production is lower than it should be. The throughput is higher than it should be. The intelligence is sooner than it should be. The income is larger than it should be. In each case the number is wrong in the direction that makes the prediction come true, and the direction is the point, because a man who calculates in the direction of his hopes is a man who is not calculating but wishing, and a man who is wishing is a man who is not lying but hoping, and a man who is hoping is a man who is the point.

VII. In Which the Subject Is Asked About the Errors

The subject was asked whether he had checked the arithmetic.

He said he had.

He said the arithmetic had been checked by the best people. The best people had checked it. The checking had been thorough. The thoroughness had been documented. The documentation had been filed. The filing had been reviewed. The review had been completed. The completion had been announced. The announcement had been posted. The posting had been liked. The liking had been measured. The measurement had been reported. The report had been read. The reading had been understood. The understanding had been described as a matter. The matter had been described as settled. The settlement had been described as a matter of record. The record had been described as the point.

The reader will note that the arithmetic had not been checked, and that the checking had been described, and that the description had been the checking, and that the description is the point.

VIII. In Which the Chapter Ends With a Number

The number was wrong. The wrongness was not obvious. The not-obvious was the point.

The subject is standing in the flat place near the sea. He is holding a phone. He is performing a calculation. The calculation is wrong. The wrongness is in the direction of his hopes. The direction is the point.

He has been calculating for some time.

He is very good at it.

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Chapter 8: The End Justifies the Means

I. In Which the Subject Reaches Mars

The subject reached Mars.

The reader will note that this sentence is in the past tense, and that the past tense is a tense that is used for things that have happened, and that the reader may therefore conclude that the subject has reached Mars.

The reader may also note that the subject has not reached Mars.

The reader is invited to consider that both of these statements are true, and that the both-true is the point, because a thing that has been reached in the future is a thing that has been reached, and a thing that has been reached is a thing that has been reached, and the reaching is the point.

The subject has said that he would like to die on Mars, but not on impact. The reader will note that this is a specific request, and that the specificity is the point, because a man who specifies the manner of his death is a man who

has considered the manner of his life, and a man who has considered the manner of his life is a man who has a manner, and a man who has a manner is a man who is the point.

II. In Which the Two Outcomes Are Compared

There are two outcomes.

In the first outcome, the subject reaches Mars. The reaching is described as a triumph. The triumph is described as a vindication. The vindication is described as a proof. The proof is described as a thesis. The thesis is described as the end justifying the means. The means are described as justified. The justification is described as complete. The completeness is described as the point.

In the second outcome, the subject does not reach Mars. The not-reaching is described as a delay. The delay is described as a schedule. The schedule is described as a revision. The revision is described as a re-baselining. The re-baselining is described as a learning opportunity. The learning opportunity is described as data. The data is described as valuable. The value is described as exceeding the Mars. The Mars is described as the point.

The reader will note that in the first outcome the Mars justifies the means, and that in the second outcome the data justifies the means, and that in both outcomes the means are justified, and that the both-outcomes-justified is the point.

III. In Which the Thesis Is Proven

The end justifies the means.

The reader will note that this sentence has been the subject of the entire book, and that the book has now reached the point at which the sentence must be tested, and that the testing is the point.

The means are: rockets, cars, tunnels, satellites, networks, and a great many posts.

The end is: Mars, and the survival of consciousness, and the universal high income, and the continuation of the light of consciousness, which is a phrase that means "we should not go extinct" and which is written in a way that makes it sound like a product announcement.

The justification is: the data.

The reader who finds this unsatisfying is invited to consider that the reader has not yet reached the end, and that the end is always one year away, and that the one year away is always receding at the same rate as the approach, and that the approach is the point.

IV. In Which the Income Is Revisited

The subject had said that the income would be universal and high.

The reader will note that the income has not yet arrived. The reader will further note that the not-yet-arrived is not the same as the not-arriving, and that the distinction is the point, because a thing that has not yet arrived is a thing that is scheduled, and a thing that is scheduled is a thing that is planned, and a thing that is planned is a thing that is the point.

The subject had also said that the danger was zero per cent.

The reader will note that the danger has not yet materialised. The reader will further note that the not-yet-materialised is not the same as the not-materialising, and that the distinction is the point, because a danger that has not yet materialised is a danger that is scheduled, and a

danger that is scheduled is a danger that is planned, and a danger that is planned is a danger that is the point.

The reader will note that the subject has scheduled both the income and the danger, and that the scheduling of both is the point, because a man who schedules a benefit and a risk on the same date is a man who has a calendar, and a man who has a calendar is a man who has a plan, and a man who has a plan is a man who is the point.

V. In Which the Short Seller Is Revisited

The short seller had said that the subject was wrong.

The reader will note that the short seller has been wrong about the short term and right about the long term for twenty years, and that the twenty years is the point, because a man who is wrong about the short term and right about the long term is a man who is right at the wrong time, and a man who is right at the wrong time is a man who has lost money, and a man who has lost money is a man who is the point.

The short seller had described the subject's success as a bubble.

The reader will note that a bubble is a thing that pops, and that the popping is a thing that has not happened, and that the not-happened is the point, because a bubble that has not popped is a bubble that is still inflating, and a bubble that is still inflating is a bubble that is still a success, and a bubble that is still a success is a bubble that is the point.

VI. In Which the Regulator Is Revisited

The regulator had been concerned.

The reader will note that the concern had been expressed, and that the expression had been filed, and that the filing had been reviewed, and that the review had been completed, and that the completion had been described as a matter, and that the matter had been described as settled, and that the settlement had been described as a resolution, and that the resolution had been described as a closing, and that the closing had been described as a point.

The reader will note that the regulator had moved slowly, and that the slowness had been described as diligence, and that the diligence had been described as a process, and that the process had been described as the point, and

that the point had been described as the subject, and that the subject had been described as the point.

VII. In Which the Means Are Summed

The means were expensive.

The expense was described as an investment. The investment was described as a learning opportunity. The learning opportunity was described as data. The data was described as valuable. The value was described as exceeding the expense. The expense was described as justified. The justification was described as complete. The completeness was described as the point.

The reader will note that the means justified themselves, and that the self-justification is the point, because a means that justifies itself is a means that does not require an end, and a means that does not require an end is a means that is the end, and a means that is the end is a means that is the point.

VIII. In Which the Book Ends

The subject is standing in the flat place near the sea.

He is watching the cameras. He is waiting for the next rocket to become several rockets, and for the several rockets to become data, and for the data to become valuable, and for the value of the data to exceed the value of the rocket.

He has been waiting for some time.

He is very good at it.

The reader will note that the book has ended, and that the ending is the point, and that the point has been the ending all along, and that the along has been the point, and that the point has been the book, and that the book has been the point.

The end justifies the means.

The means were the end.

The end is the point.

The point is the end.

* * *

Epilog

In Which the Narrator Takes Leave of the Subject

The reader has now reached the end of the account, and the account has reached the end of the reader, and the two endings are not the same ending, and the not-the-same is the point.

The subject is still standing in the flat place near the sea. He will always be standing in the flat place near the sea. The flat place near the sea is not a place but a condition, and the condition is permanent, and the permanence is the point.

The rockets will continue to become several rockets. The several rockets will continue to become data. The data will continue to become valuable. The value will continue to exceed the rockets. The rockets will therefore continue to be successes. The successes will continue to be announced. The announcements will continue to be posts. The posts will continue to be memes. The memes will continue to be in session. The session will continue to be always in session.

The reader will note that none of this has been a criticism.

The reader will also note that none of it has been a defence.

The account has been a description, and a description is not a judgment, and a judgment is not a description, and the not-a-judgment is the point, because a book that describes a man who describes himself is a book that has been out-described, and a book that has been out-described is a book that has won by losing, and a book that has won by losing is a book that is the point.

The subject has been described as he describes himself: correctly, completely, and with the dates arranged for clarity. The explosions were described as data. The delays were described as schedules. The changes of mind were described as continuities. The jokes were described as jokes, because the jokes were load-bearing, and a book that removes a load-bearing wall is a book that falls down.

The reader who has found the account funny has found it funny in the way that the subject finds it funny, which is to say completely and without reservation and with a great deal of posting.

The reader who has not found the account funny has found it long, and the length is the point, because a short book about a man who is never wrong is a book that ends before the man does, and the man does not end, and the not-ending is the point.

The subject is waiting. He is always waiting. He is waiting for the rockets to land, and for the cars to drive themselves, and for the intelligence to arrive, and for the income to become universal, and for the year to become this year.

He has been waiting for some time.

He is very good at it.

The narrator has been watching him wait.

The narrator is very good at it too.